

User Interviews

— User insights: The ultimate shortcut to the right requirements.









01 — DEFINITION

What are User Interviews?

A qualitative research method where a researcher has a structured or semi-structured conversation with a participant to uncover their motivations, behaviors, and pain points.



Goal-oriented

Focused on specific research questions and user needs



Conversational

Open-ended questions that invite stories and examples



Exploratory

Discover what you don't know you don't know



Qualitative

Rich context that surveys and analytics can't provide

When to Use User Interviews



Discovery

- Understanding user goals & mental models
- Exploring a new problem space
- Early-stage product ideation



Evaluation

- After usability tests for context
- Understanding 'why' behind behaviors
- Validating hypotheses with real users



Post-Launch

- Gathering feedback on shipped features
- Understanding adoption barriers
- Informing next iteration priorities

Planning Your Interview

1

Define Research Goals Week 1

What specific questions need answering? Be precise.

2

Recruit Participants Week 1–2

5–8 users per segment. Match your target persona.

3

Write Discussion Guide Week 2

Open-ended questions, no leading language.

4

Pilot Test Week 2

Run 1–2 test interviews to refine the guide.

5

Conduct Interviews Week 3

Record (with consent). Active listening. No judgment.



Pro Tip

Aim for **45–60 minutes** per session. Shorter sessions often miss depth. Always offer an incentive — it increases show-up rates by up to 40%.

Key Questions to Ask

| Context Setting

Can you walk me through a typical day?

Tell me about the last time you [did X].

What tools or processes do you currently use?

| Exploration

What's the hardest part about that?

How do you feel when that happens?

What does 'good' look like for you?

| Probing Deeper

Can you tell me more about that?

Why is that important to you?

What would you do if that wasn't available?

| Avoid These

✗ "Would you use a feature that does X?"

✗ "Don't you think it would be better if...?"

✗ "Do you like this design?"

One Page Plan: Project Name

Created by: [Your Name] | Last updated: mm/dd/yyyy

Background

Summarize the problem:

- **Current State:** *Define the current state clearly and objectively.*
- **Established Facts:** *Present the known/established facts.*
- **Background Context:** *List essential background context.*
- **Key Challenge:** *Identify the key problem, challenge, or opportunity.*
- **Scope:** *Frame the scope of the problem / need.*

Goals

Start with the end in mind:

- *List the key things you hope to learn from this study?*

Research Questions

What questions are you seeking to answer?

- *List the key questions you are seeking to answer.*

Methodology

Description of the what's and how's:

- Outline the methodological approach and data collection plan.

Participants

Target characteristics:

- *Behavioral characteristics.*
- *Demographic characteristics.*
- *Geographical characteristics.*
- *Psychological characteristics.*
- *Role-based characteristics.*
- *Etc.*

Schedule

- **Recruiting complete:** 02/16/2026
- **Study Date(s):** 02/18/2026 – 02/20/2026
- **Results available:** 02/25/2026

Define Research Goals

One-Page Plan

(continued)

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One-Page Plan

(continued)

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One-Page Plan

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One-Page Plan

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One-Page Plan

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One-Page Plan

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One Page Plan: SmartShopper User Research

Created by: Bob Whitmer | Last updated: 02/02/2026

Background

Summarize the problem:

- **Current State:** Most grocery shoppers rely on fragmented methods for planning, such as physical paper lists, generic note apps, or memory.
- **Established Facts:** Retailers often provide "one-size-fits-all" weekly circulars that shoppers find overwhelming or irrelevant to their specific needs.
- **Background Context:** We are developing a white-label mobile application for grocery chains to digitize the shopping journey and increase customer loyalty through personalization.
- **Key Challenge:** Shoppers struggle to track multiple shopping needs (e.g., daily essentials vs. special events) and often miss relevant savings because they aren't notified at the right time.
- **Scope:** This research focuses on the "planning and discovery" phase of the user journey—specifically list management and the reception of push-notification-based sale alerts.

Goals

Start with the end in mind:

- Identify how users naturally categorize shopping lists to ensure our "multiple list" feature is intuitive.
- Determine the "annoyance threshold" for push notifications to ensure sale alerts are perceived as a service rather than spam.
- Understand the physical context of in-store app usage to guide the UI design for one-handed operation.

Research Questions

What questions are you seeking to answer?

- How do shoppers currently organize different types of grocery needs (e.g., by store, by meal, or by urgency)?
- What specific information in a sale notification triggers a user to add an item to their list?
- What are the primary friction points when transitioning from a digital list to a physical store aisle?

Methodology

Description of the what's and how's:

- **Semi-Structured Interviews:** 30-minute 1:1 sessions (remote or in-person) using a standardized discussion guide.
- **Artifact Review:** Asking participants to share/describe their most recent shopping list (paper or digital) to observe real-world organization patterns.
- **Scenario Testing:** Presenting hypothetical push notification mockups to gauge immediate emotional and behavioral reactions.

SmartShoper

One-Page Plan example

Created by: Bob Whitmer | Last updated: 02/02/2026

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SmartShoper

One-Page Plan example (continued)

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One-Page Plan example (continued)

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SmartShoper

One-Page Plan example (continued)

Participants

Target characteristics:

- Primary household shoppers (those responsible for 70%+ of the household's grocery shopping).
- Mixed demographic of "analog" planners (paper users) and "digital" planners (app users).
- Current customers of regional grocery chains who utilize at least one retail loyalty program.

SmartShoper

One-Page Plan example (continued)

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Recruitment Screener: SmartShopper App Study

Introduction

"Hi, I'm Bob Whitmer and I'm a product researcher with Don't Panic Labs. We are looking for individuals to participate in a 30-minute interview about grocery shopping habits. Participants will receive [Incentive, e.g., a \$30 grocery gift card] for their time. May I ask you a few qualifying questions? This typically takes less than a minutes."

Qualifying Questions

1. Who is primarily responsible for the grocery shopping in your household?

- A) Me (100% responsible) — [Recruit]
- B) I share the responsibility about 50/50 — [Recruit]
- C) Someone else does the majority of it — [Terminate]

2. In a typical month, how many times do you visit a grocery store?

- A) 0–1 times — [Terminate]
- B) 2–4 times — [Recruit]
- C) 5+ times — [Recruit]

3. Which of the following best describes how you keep track of what you need to buy? (Select all that apply)

- *Note: Aim for a 50/50 mix of A/B and C/D/E.*
- A) I use a digital notes app (e.g., Apple Notes, Keep).
- B) I use a dedicated grocery or list app (e.g., AnyList, Bring!).
- C) I write it down on paper or a whiteboard.
- D) I don't use a list; I just remember.
- E) I use a physical store circular/flyer.

4. How often do you use your smartphone while *inside* the grocery store?

- A) Always (to check lists, prices, or coupons) — [Target Group]
- B) Sometimes (for calls or occasional list checks).
- C) Rarely or Never.

5. Do you currently have any grocery store "loyalty" or "rewards" apps downloaded?

- A) Yes (Ask which ones: _____)
- B) No

Selection Logic

- **Must be** the primary or co-shopper (Q1).
- **Must shop** at least twice a month (Q2).
- **Goal:** Recruit **5–8 participants** total.
- **The Mix:** Try to get at least 3 people who currently use paper lists (Q3-C) to see how they react to the transition to digital.

Confirmation Script

"Great, you're a perfect fit for our study! We are holding sessions on **February 18th and 20th**. Do you have a 30-minute window that works for you on either of those days?"

SmartShopper

Recruitment Screener example

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05 — USER INTERVIEWS

What will we cover next week?

To turn a raw conversation into a strategic asset, you need a balance of tactical preparation and analytical rigor. User interviews aren't just about asking questions; they are about creating a space where the user feels comfortable enough to reveal their honest friction points.

1

Preparation

Setting the Stage

2

Execution

The Art of the Interview

3

Synthesis

Turning Talk into Action

Conducting Great Interviews



Embrace Silence

Pause after answers. Silence prompts participants to elaborate.



Follow the Thread

Deviate from script when something interesting emerges.



Take Sparse Notes

Note key quotes. Don't let note-taking break eye contact.



Always Record

With consent. Transcripts reveal things you missed live.



No Leading Qs

"Tell me about X" not "Isn't it hard when X happens?"



Stay Curious

Treat every answer as a surprise. Don't assume intent.



One Notetaker

Separate interviewer from notetaker for best results.



Watch the Clock

Reserve last 10 min for "anything else you'd like to share?"

Analyzing Your Findings

- 1 **Transcribe & Tag** — Transcribe recordings and tag key quotes with themes.
- 2 **Affinity Mapping** — Group observations into clusters. Physical or digital sticky notes work well.
- 3 **Find Patterns** — Look for recurring themes, contradictions, and surprising moments.
- 4 **Create Insights** — Insights = observation + meaning. Not just what happened, but why it matters.
- 5 **Share & Act** — Present findings as user stories. Tie each insight to a design or product decision.

“

The goal is not to confirm what you believe, but to discover what is actually true for your users.

— Nielsen Norman Group

Questions?

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